EvoCrypt: A Runtime-Upgradable Cryptographic Coprocessor for the Ethereum Virtual Machine

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Abstract. Smart contracts frequently rely on cryptographic algorithms, yet implementing complex cryptographic computation in Solidity expands it into large sequences of EVM instructions, resulting in substantial execution overhead and gas consumption. Precompiled Contracts reduce these costs by exposing client-side routines at fixed addresses, but they provide no runtime mechanism for evolving an algorithm independently of client releases and coordinated network upgrades. We present EvoCrypt, an upgradeable cryptographic coprocessor framework that exposes a stable contract-facing interface while executing replaceable WebAssembly (WASM) modules in a controlled client-side runtime. EvoCrypt distributes version metadata on-chain and deterministically activates an installed module at a designated block height, allowing participating nodes to switch algorithm versions consistently. Each invocation follows a deterministic gas rule: normally a version-registered charge, or the gas component of the corresponding upgrade proposal, avoiding expansion of the algorithm into EVM instructions while retaining explicit accounting. We implement EvoCrypt in Geth and evaluate it on a 20-node private network. The experiments show that EvoCrypt improves the efficiency of contract-facing cryptographic upgrades and invocations compared with Solidity-based implementations, while retaining near-Precompiled-Contract execution costs for most benchmark algorithms. EvoCrypt also supports the deployment of complex cryptographic algorithms that are difficult to realize directly in the EVM ecosystem.

Keywords: blockchain · smart contracts · upgrade · WebAssembly

1 Introduction

As blockchain systems become programmable platforms, smart contracts increasingly depend on cryptographic algorithms for authentication, integrity, signatures, and privacy [1–4]. The long-term security of these applications also requires the ability to adopt new algorithms, including post-quantum alternatives, without disrupting contract-facing functionality [5–7]. Blockchain clients therefore need an extensible way to provide evolving cryptographic capabilities to smart contracts.

Ethereum provides two main mechanisms for executing cryptographic operations: Solidity contract implementations and Precompiled Contracts. Solidity implementations are flexible and deployable at the contract layer, but complex cryptographic computation expands into costly EVM execution; Precompiled

Contracts execute selected routines efficiently in client-side code, but their supported algorithms are fixed to the client and normally require coordinated client updates to change [3, 4, 8].

Together, these mechanisms expose a fundamental trade-off between execution efficiency and algorithm upgradability. Solidity keeps algorithms deployable without client changes but can impose substantial execution and gas overhead, whereas Precompiled Contracts provide efficient execution only for routines embedded in the client and are therefore difficult to evolve independently. The central challenge is to replace contract-facing cryptographic implementations without sacrificing efficient execution, deterministic behavior across nodes, or compatibility with the existing EVM interface.

EvoCrypt addresses this trade-off by separating the stable contract-facing interface from replaceable WASM implementations and by separating module preparation from module activation. The interface preserves how smart contracts invoke cryptographic operations, while portable WASM modules allow implementations to be replaced without embedding each algorithm in contract bytecode or rebuilding the client for every change. Asynchronous preparation moves verification, compilation, and instantiation away from the transaction execution path. Activation-Block-based selection then ensures that nodes switch versions according to a common chain-derived rule rather than local readiness time. The design combines algorithm-level accounting with deterministic, incrementally deployable upgrades.

The main contributions of this article are summarized as follows.

- First, we design an upgradeable cryptographic coprocessor that separates the stable contract-facing interface from replaceable WASM-based algorithm implementations, allowing complex cryptographic operations to execute outside the EVM while preserving contract compatibility.
- Second, we design an activation-block-based upgrade protocol in which upgrade proposals are published on-chain. Each proposal has three parts: algorithm information, a gas rule bound to that algorithm, and control information comprising the Activation Block and the hash used to verify the WASM bytecode. Clients derive the same proposal from this record and therefore execute the same module once the upgrade becomes active.
- Finally, we implement EvoCrypt in Geth and evaluate it on a 20-node private blockchain network. The results show that EvoCrypt reduces the implementation burden and calling cost of the evaluated cryptographic operations while supporting dynamic evolution of contract-facing algorithms.

2 Related Work

Research on cryptographic algorithm upgrades in blockchain systems has not yet resolved the combined problem of efficient invocation and practical implementation. Related approaches can be organized by the layer at which they support upgrades: protocol and client, contract, or dynamic runtime.

Blockchain upgrades at the protocol or client layer replace execution rules through a coordinated transition. Cardano switches protocol eras with a hard-fork combinator at designated heights, and work on updatable blockchains studies how old and new chains stay synchronized [9–11]. Soft forks encode selected policy changes in rules that can be adopted without replacing the protocol [12]. Phoenix and Polkadot are closest to EvoCrypt in supporting live replacement: Phoenix compiles upgrade code carried in transactions at runtime, while Polkadot replaces governance-approved on-chain WASM runtime logic during block synchronization [13, 14]. Both nevertheless replace client or chain-runtime components rather than a contract-facing cryptographic algorithm. They do not specify how a contract names an algorithm, binds its interface, or switches versions without redeploying the caller. EvoCrypt narrows the replacement boundary to individual WASM modules behind a stable Solidity-facing interface. Consistency follows from an on-chain proposal whose control fields carry the module hash and Activation Block, and whose gas fields are bound to the individual algorithm.

Contract-level schemes update application logic without replacing the entire blockchain client, using deployable contracts, proxy indirection, or bytecode rewriting. EVMPatch patches deployed Ethereum smart contracts through bytecode rewriting and proxy-based deployment, while Solidity implementations offer application-level flexibility within the EVM [15, 4]. LEAGAN extends contract-level upgradeability through data separation, incremental hashing, revision control, and status-contract-based version management [16]. Precompiled Contracts provide a complementary client-side path for selected cryptographic routines through reserved EVM-facing addresses [8, 17, 18]. Contract-level implementations remain constrained by EVM execution cost and state or interface compatibility, whereas adding or replacing a Precompiled Contract normally requires changes to client and protocol rules.

Dynamic software-update schemes move replacement below the application layer by loading new components into a running host. KylinX supports runtime library replacement through dynamic mapping, Mvedsua combines dynamic updates with multi-version execution, PYLIVE changes Python code online, and distributed-system research addresses modular updates and version consistency [19–23]. WASM provides a portable artifact format and explicit host boundary for this style of replacement. In blockchain systems, existing WASM-based upgrades generally target broad runtime logic rather than a narrow EVM-facing cryptographic interface [24, 14].

3 EvoCrypt Design

EvoCrypt is a cryptographic coprocessor framework for dynamically upgrading contract-facing cryptographic algorithms. This section presents the system model, the upgrade protocol, and the invocation protocol that together define the design. We focus on the coordination, version-selection, and contract-facing

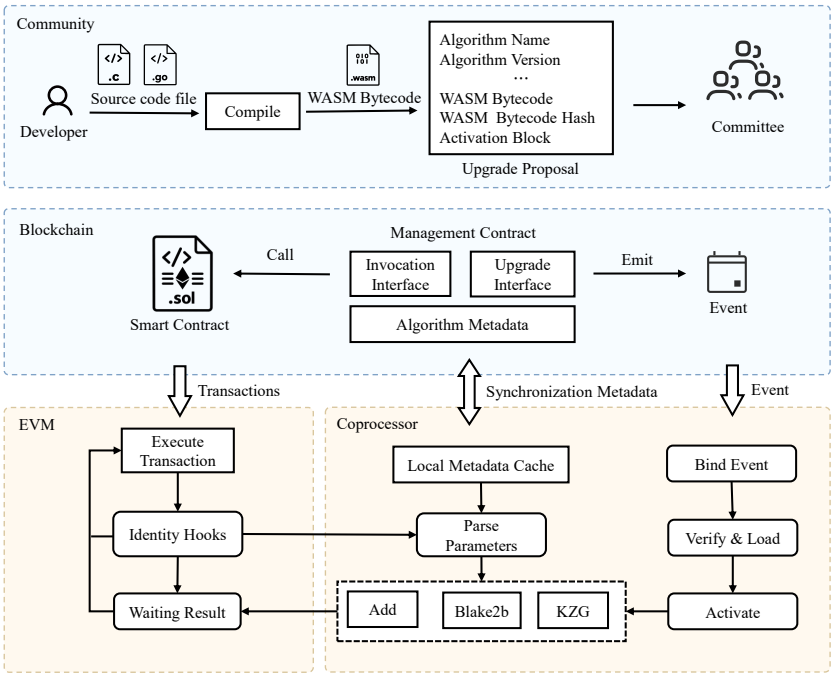


Fig. 1. System model for proposed EvoCrypt framework.

execution rules of EvoCrypt, while the prototype implementation and experimental configuration are described in Section 5.

3.1 System Model

EvoCrypt separates governance, chain state, contract execution, and module execution into four cooperating components: the Community, the Blockchain, the EVM, and the Cryptographic Coprocessor. The Community includes developers and an authorizing committee that proposes and approves algorithm upgrades. The Blockchain maintains the canonical chain and shared world state, including smart contracts and the Management Contract. The EVM processes smart-contract transactions, while the node-local Cryptographic Coprocessor prepares, activates, and executes replaceable cryptographic modules.

Two chain-derived paths connect these components. An approved proposer records an upgrade through the Management Contract, whereas a contract initiates an invocation through the EVM of a Blockchain node. The Management Contract stores each admitted upgrade proposal, including the gas rule bound to its algorithm, and exposes the contract-facing upgrade and invocation interfaces. The coprocessor uses the resulting chain state to prepare and execute the corresponding module. Figure 1 summarizes these objects and their relationships.

3.2 Upgrade Protocol

On-chain publication. On-chain publication provides the authoritative record that coordinates node-local preparation and height-based activation. After the committee approves a proposal, a committee-authorized proposer submits it through the designated upgrade interface. The Management Contract admits the proposal only after the committee has reached consensus on its three parts, stores that record, and emits an upgrade event.

The EVM records the proposal but does not compile or instantiate the WASM module. Node-dependent preparation therefore remains outside the transaction that changes the chain state. Every node reconstructs the same version from the admitted proposal. Its algorithm part names the algorithm and version and fixes the entry and output parameters; its gas part supplies the pricing rule bound to that algorithm; its control part supplies the Activation Block and the hash used to verify the bytecode. Only $\langle a, v, H_{a,v} \rangle$ is emitted as a notification index. Let $\mathcal{V}_a$ denote the versions already registered for algorithm a; the authoritative record prevents nodes from preparing different artifacts or execution rules for the same upgrade.

Definition 1 (Upgrade proposal). *Let a be an algorithm name and v a version number. An admitted upgrade proposal has an algorithm component, a gas component, and a control component,*

$$\mu_{a,v} = \big(\mathsf{Alg}_{a,v},\, \Gamma_{a,v},\, \mathsf{Ctl}_{a,v}\big), \tag{1}$$

$$\mathsf{Alg}_{a,v} = \big(a,\, v,\, C_{a,v},\, \tau^{\mathrm{in}}_{a,v},\, \tau^{\mathrm{out}}_{a,v}\big), \tag{2}$$

$$\Gamma_{a,v} = \big(g^{\mathrm{reg}}_{a,v},\, B_a,\, \alpha_a,\, N_{0,a}\big), \tag{3}$$

$$\mathsf{Ctl}_{a,v} = \big(H_{a,v},\, h_{a,v}\big). \tag{4}$$

The algorithm component carries the compiled WASM bytecode $C_{a,v}$ together with the entry-parameter descriptor $\tau^{\mathrm{in}}_{a,v}$ and the output-parameter descriptor $\tau^{\mathrm{out}}_{a,v}$. The gas component carries the version's registered charge $g^{\mathrm{reg}}_{a,v}$ and the pricing parameters of algorithm a: the input-size band B_a, the growth parameter α_a, and the call threshold $N_{0,a}$. The control component carries the Activation Block height $H_{a,v}$ and the verification hash $h_{a,v} = \mathrm{Keccak256}(C_{a,v})$. The Management Contract stores an encoding of all three components. Each node recomputes the hash from the recovered bytecode during preparation and accepts the module only when the result equals $h_{a,v}$.

Node-local preparation. Node-local preparation converts the admitted metadata record into executable state without changing the active version. After observing the upgrade event, each client recovers $\mu_{a,v}$, checks that the event index agrees with the stored record, decodes the artifact, and recomputes its hash. The Upgrade Handler then compiles and instantiates the module and validates its required entry point. Once these checks succeed, the node records (a, v) as prepared. Algorithm 1 gives the complete publication and preparation procedure.

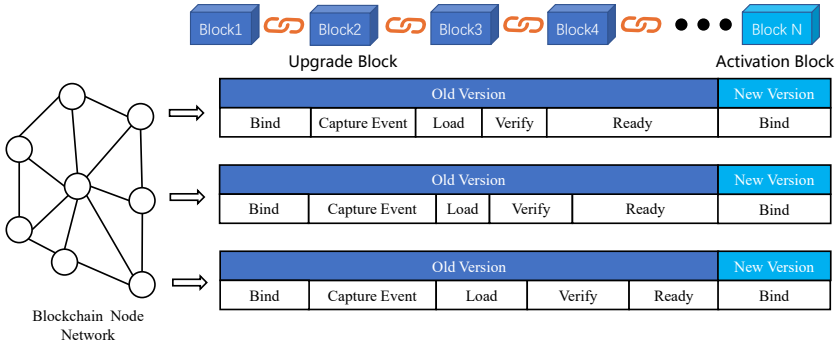


Fig. 2. Node-local preparation and deterministic activation of an EvoCrypt upgrade.

Preparation is deliberately separated from the chain-level upgrade record. Node-local work can proceed asynchronously, failed attempts can retry from the authoritative chain record, and an executed upgrade transaction is not rolled back. The separation allows preparation to complete without changing the version selected by the chain.

Algorithm 1 Activation-Block-based WASM upgrade protocol.

Require: Upgrade proposal $\mu_{a,v}$ as in (1); node set $\mathcal{N}$
Ensure: Prepared set updated on every $n_i \in \mathcal{N}$
committee-authorized proposer submits $\mu_{a,v}$ through the designated upgrade interface
Management Contract stores $\mu_{a,v}$; emits event $\langle a, v, H_{a,v} \rangle$
for all $n_i \in \mathcal{N}$ **do**
    observe $\langle a, v, H_{a,v} \rangle$; fetch $\mu'_{a,v}$ from Management Contract
    if event fields disagree with $\mu'_{a,v}$ **then**
        reject (a, v)
    else
        decode $\widehat{C}$ from $\mu'_{a,v}$; reject (a, v) unless Keccak256$(\widehat{C}) = h_{a,v}$
        repeat
            compile and instantiate $\widehat{C}$; validate the required module entry point
        until preparation succeeds
        persist $\widehat{C}$ under $h_{a,v}$ with $\mu_{a,v}$; mark (a, v) prepared
    end if
end for

Height-based activation. Height-based activation makes the selected version a function of shared chain height rather than node-local preparation time. The Upgrade Block includes the admitted upgrade transaction and emits $\langle a, v, H_{a,v} \rangle$. After that block, each node independently completes the off-chain Load–Verify–Ready sequence, while invocations before $H_{a,v}$ continue to use the previously selected version. At the Activation Block, nodes with the same chain view select

version v according to the rule below. Compilation-time differences therefore cannot change the version selected at a given execution height.

When a selected version is not yet prepared, the node reloads its authoritative metadata and continues preparation rather than selecting an obsolete version. The policy preserves height-based selection while allowing node-local readiness to complete asynchronously. Figure 2 shows the separation between publication, preparation, and activation.

Definition 2 (Active version). *Let $\mathcal{V}_a$ be the registered version set of algorithm a, and let b be the execution block height. The version used at height b is*

$$v^*(a,b) = \arg\max_{v \in \mathcal{V}_a} \{(H_{a,v},\, v) \mid H_{a,v} \le b\}\,. \tag{5}$$

The arg max *is lexicographic on the pair $(H_{a,v}, v)$: among versions whose activation height does not exceed b, the rule prefers the latest activation height and, for a tied height, the larger version number. If the feasible set is empty, no version is active and the invocation fails with a missing-version error.*

3.3 Invocation Protocol

A unified Management Contract entry point keeps the contract-facing call boundary stable. The caller serializes the algorithm name a and its parameters into an encoded request x and submits it through the designated interface, so different algorithms share one destination address and the contract binds to the ABI descriptors of the selected version rather than to module location, implementation language, or node-local loading state. EVM-side Hooks admit only requests to that interface; all others remain on the ordinary EVM path. For a routed request the coprocessor parses (a, x), resolves $v^*(a, b)$ by (5), and, under the mandatory-preparation policy, prepares the selected version if necessary rather than falling back to an obsolete implementation. The selected module receives the encoded parameters and returns an encoded result; the call shape remains compatible when $\tau^{\text{in}}_{a,v}$ and $\tau^{\text{out}}_{a,v}$ are compatible. Algorithm 2 specifies this procedure and its protocol-error conditions.

Definition 3 (Algorithm-level gas schedule). *Let $i \ge 1$ be one plus the number of earlier charged calls to algorithm a within the current transaction, and let b be its execution height. The pricing parameters B_a, α_a, and $N_{0,a}$ come from the gas component $\Gamma_{a,v}$ of the admitted proposal. The charge $G(a, v, x, i, b)$ equals $G_{\text{prof}}(a, v, x, i)$ when that component supplies a pricing rule, and equals $g^{\text{reg}}_{a,v}$ otherwise. For that rule,*

$$G_{\text{prof}}(a,v,x,i) = \left\lceil B_a(|x|)(1+\alpha_a)^{\max(0,\,i-N_{0,a})} \right\rceil, \tag{6}$$

where B_a selects the input-size band stored for a, $N_{0,a}$ is that algorithm's transaction-local call threshold, and α_a is its growth parameter. The current implementation passes a zero parent-call count, so the load multiplier of this rule is one. The

index resets for each transaction and algorithm. The algorithm's pricing rule replaces*, rather than adds to,* $g^{\mathrm{reg}}_{a,v}$*; an invalid or missing configured version is an error, not a fallback to the registered charge. The versioned consistency model treats* $g^{\mathrm{reg}}_{a,v}$ *as immutable and excludes the legacy* `updataGas` *mutation path. The transaction's total gas additionally includes ordinary EVM, calldata, and intrinsic costs.*

Algorithm 2 Contract-to-coprocessor invocation protocol.

Require: Recognized invocation request d, block height b, gas budget g
Ensure: ABI-encoded result y or explicit error
1: $(a, x) \leftarrow \mathrm{Parse}(d)$
2: **if** the request is invalid **then**
3: **return** ABI error
4: **end if**
5: $v \leftarrow v^*(a, b)$ by (5)
6: **if** no applicable version exists **then**
7: **return** missing-version error
8: **end if**
9: ensure (a, v) is prepared under the mandatory-preparation policy
10: $G_{\mathrm{req}} \leftarrow G(a, v, x, i, b)$ by Definition 3
11: **if** $g < G_{\mathrm{req}}$ **then**
12: **return** out-of-gas error
13: **end if**
14: charge G_{req}; $y \leftarrow \mathrm{Execute}(a, v, x)$
15: **return** y, or runtime error on failure

Because G depends only on the selected version, the pricing parameters in the admitted proposal, the encoded input size, and the transaction-local call index, nodes executing the same transaction prefix charge the same amount independently of local CPU time or WASM instruction counts. The coefficients used for the evaluated algorithm in Section 5 demonstrate an experimental tariff rather than a calibrated economic optimum.

4 Security Analysis

This section formalizes the upgrade protocol and derives the invocation guarantees from it. Section 4.1 fixes the ledger and registry abstractions, the trusted assumptions, the adversary, and game-based definitions for the two failure modes an upgrade mechanism must exclude: honest nodes selecting different versions for the same height, and an honest node executing bytecode other than the admitted artifact. Section 4.2 shows that EvoCrypt excludes the first unconditionally relative to the ledger abstraction and the second by a tight reduction to the collision resistance of Keccak256, and combines both into an upgrade-soundness theorem. Section 4.3 extends consistency to invocation outcomes and

proves resistance to gas-charge evasion, and Section 4.4 treats the residual risks the model leaves open and the governed recovery path that addresses them.

4.1 Security Model

Notation and ledger. κ is the security parameter, $\mathsf{negl}(\kappa)$ a negligible function, and algorithms are probabilistic polynomial time (PPT) unless stated otherwise. $\mathcal{N}$ is the set of honest nodes, each running Algorithms 1 and 2. The proposal $\mu_{a,v}$ and the fields $C_{a,v}$, $h_{a,v}$, and $H_{a,v}$ are the algorithm and control components in Definition 1, and $u_{a,v}$ denotes the height of the Upgrade Block that admitted $\mu_{a,v}$. We abstract the blockchain as a transaction ledger: honest node n holds a local view $\mathcal{L}_n$, a finite block sequence with prefix $\mathcal{L}_n[1..b]$ and height $|\mathcal{L}_n|$. Transaction order inside a block is part of the ledger, so an execution point is a height together with a position in the block; we write b for both.

Definition 4 (Registry state). *The registry* $\mathsf{Reg}(P)$ *of a ledger prefix* P *is the Management Contract storage obtained by executing* P *from the genesis state; by EVM determinism it is a function of* P*. For a node* n *and height* b*, let* $\mathcal{V}_a^n(b) = \{v \mid \mu_{a,v} \in \mathsf{Reg}(\mathcal{L}_n[1..b])\}$ *and let* $v_n^*(a,b)$ *be the value of* (5) *over* $\mathcal{V}_a^n(b)$*, with* $v_n^*(a,b) = \perp$ *when the feasible set is empty.*

Definition 4 fixes the version each honest node selects from its ledger prefix. Agreement on that version, and execution of the admitted artifact, both depend on assumptions that we now make explicit. Assumptions 1–3 are used for upgrade soundness in Section 4.2, and Assumption 4 only when Section 4.3 extends consistency to invocation outcomes.

Assumption 1 (Canonical ledger). *For all honest* $n, n' \in \mathcal{N}$ *and every* $b \leq \min(|\mathcal{L}_n|, |\mathcal{L}_{n'}|)$*,* $\mathcal{L}_n[1..b] = \mathcal{L}_{n'}[1..b]$*. The gas parameters on that prefix are those in the admitted proposals.*

Prefix equality expresses ledger persistence [25]; the gas parameters are fields of the admitted proposals on that prefix. Blocks subject to reorganization are re-executed by ordinary EVM rules and lie outside the model.

Assumption 2 (Committee-gated admission). *The Management Contract admits* $\mu_{a,v}$ *only on a committee-authorized submission, and every admitted record is well formed: (i)* $h_{a,v} = \mathrm{Keccak256}(C_{a,v})$*; (ii)* $u_{a,v} < H_{a,v}$*, i.e., the record is committed strictly before its Activation Block; (iii)* (a,v) *is unique, and an admitted record is never modified or removed; (iv)* $C_{a,v}$ *passes validation of the configured WASM Runtime. The committee is further trusted to review the implementation and its registered gas charge before admission. Conditions (i)–(iii) can be enforced by the contract itself; listing them as assumptions keeps the analysis independent of the contract implementation.*

Assumption 3 (Collision resistance). *For every PPT algorithm* $\mathcal{B}$*,*

$$\mathsf{Adv}^{\mathrm{cr}}_{\mathrm{Keccak256}}(\mathcal{B}) = \Pr\big[(C, C') \leftarrow \mathcal{B}(1^\kappa) : C \neq C' \wedge \mathrm{Keccak256}(C) = \mathrm{Keccak256}(C')\big] \leq \mathsf{negl}(\kappa). \tag{7}$$

Keccak256 is unkeyed, so (7) is read in the concrete sense of Rogaway [26]: each reduction below exhibits an explicit collision finder $\mathcal{B}$ and bounds the protocol adversary's advantage by that of $\mathcal{B}$.

Assumption 4 (Deterministic runtime). *The WASM Runtime exposes a validation predicate* $\mathsf{Validate}(C) \in \{0,1\}$ *and an execution function* $\mathsf{Exec}(C, x)$ *whose outputs, including error outcomes, depend only on* (C, x) *and the fixed, allowlisted host interface. It enforces bounded linear memory, import validation and the configured resource limits, and exposes no host state or capability beyond that interface.*

Adversary. The PPT adversary $\mathcal{A}$ may (a) submit arbitrary transactions, including invocation inputs and candidate upgrade proposals, the latter admitted only subject to Assumption 2; (b) schedule the delivery of upgrade events, delay or interrupt node-local preparation, and crash and restart nodes so that preparation retries; and (c) tamper with the node-local artifact path, i.e., replace the byte sequence $\widehat{C}$ that a node obtains when it decodes, persists or reloads an artifact, modelling corrupted caches, persisted copies and untrusted retrieval channels. It cannot violate Assumptions 1–3, forge committee authorization, or alter the client binary. The model thus excludes a compromised Geth binary, a broken consensus protocol, a captured committee, a failed implementation review, and a primitive whose underlying assumption is false.
Security definitions. Each experiment below runs $\mathcal{A}$ against the honest nodes in this model and outputs 1 when $\mathcal{A}$ causes the undesirable event; the advantage of $\mathcal{A}$ is the probability of output 1 over all coins.

Definition 5 (Version divergence). *In* $\mathsf{Exp}^{\mathrm{div}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa)$*, the adversary finally outputs a tuple* (a, b, n, n') *with* $n, n' \in \mathcal{N}$ *and* $b \leq \min(|\mathcal{L}_n|, |\mathcal{L}_{n'}|)$*. The experiment outputs* 1 *iff* $v^*_n(a,b) \neq v^*_{n'}(a,b)$*, where* $\perp$ *differs from every version.* $\mathsf{Adv}^{\mathrm{div}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa) = \Pr[\mathsf{Exp}^{\mathrm{div}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa) = 1]$.

Definition 6 (Module substitution). $\mathsf{Exp}^{\mathrm{sub}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa)$ *outputs* 1 *iff some honest node* n *marks* (a, v) *as prepared with, or executes for* (a, v)*, a byte sequence* $\widehat{C}$ *such that* $\mu_{a,v} \in \mathsf{Reg}(\mathcal{L}_n)$ *and* $\widehat{C} \neq C_{a,v}$. $\mathsf{Adv}^{\mathrm{sub}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa) = \Pr[\mathsf{Exp}^{\mathrm{sub}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa) = 1]$.

Definition 7 (Upgrade soundness). $\mathsf{Exp}^{\mathrm{bind}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa)$ *outputs* 1 *iff some honest node executes an invocation of* a *at height* b *with a byte sequence* $\widehat{C} \neq C_{a,v^*(a,b)}$*, where* $v^*(a,b)$ *is evaluated on the canonical prefix of height* b*; executing any module when* $v^*(a,b) = \perp$ *also counts as output* 1*. EvoCrypt is* upgrade sound *if* $\mathsf{Adv}^{\mathrm{bind}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa) = \Pr[\mathsf{Exp}^{\mathrm{bind}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa) = 1]$ *is negligible for every PPT* $\mathcal{A}$*.*

Definition 7 is the target property: whatever $\mathcal{A}$ does to scheduling and node-local storage, every honest node that answers an invocation runs exactly the artifact the canonical chain designates for that height. Definitions 5 and 6 isolate the two ways this can fail.

Definition 8 (Gas-charge evasion). *In* $\mathsf{Exp}^{\mathrm{gas}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa)$, $\mathcal{A}$ *submits invocation transactions, choosing their inputs, call-gas budgets, and repeated calls, and finally identifies an invocation of* a *at execution point* b *on an honest node* n*. Let* x *be its parsed input,* g *its available gas before charging, and* i *one plus the number of earlier charged calls to* a *in the same transaction, as in Definition 3. Set* $G^* = G(a, v^*(a,b), x, i, b)$ *using the gas component of the admitted proposal for* a*. The experiment outputs* 1 *iff the invocation reaches line 14 with either* $g < G^*$ *or a coprocessor charge* $\gamma < G^*$*; it outputs* 0 *if the request or pricing data is invalid, no version is active, or execution is not reached. Thus the attack succeeds by bypassing the gas-budget check or obtaining execution below the scheduled charge. Define* $\mathsf{Adv}^{\mathrm{gas}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa) = \Pr[\mathsf{Exp}^{\mathrm{gas}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa) = 1]$.

4.2 Upgrade Security

Lemma 1 (Activation timeliness). *Under Assumption 2, for every honest node* n *and every* $\mu_{a,v} \in \mathsf{Reg}(\mathcal{L}_n)$*: (i)* $v^*_n(a,b) \neq v$ *for every* $b < H_{a,v}$*, and (ii)* v *lies in the feasible set of* (5) *at every* b *with* $H_{a,v} \leq b \leq |\mathcal{L}_n|$.

Proof. (i) The feasible set contains only versions with $H_{a,v} \leq b$. (ii) By Assumption 2(ii), $u_{a,v} < H_{a,v} \leq b$, so the admitting transaction lies in $\mathcal{L}_n[1..b]$, and by (iii) the record is never removed; hence $\mu_{a,v} \in \mathsf{Reg}(\mathcal{L}_n[1..b])$ and $H_{a,v} \leq b$ places v in the feasible set. □

The lemma confines the preparation window of (a, v) to heights $u_{a,v} < b < H_{a,v}$ and excludes retroactive activation: appending a block never changes the version designated for an already-executed height, so a node replaying history agrees with nodes that executed it live.

Theorem 1 (Activation consistency). *Under Assumptions 1 and 2, every adversary* $\mathcal{A}$*, including a computationally unbounded one, has* $\mathsf{Adv}^{\mathrm{div}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa) = 0$.

Proof. Fix any output (a, b, n, n') of $\mathcal{A}$. By Assumption 1, $P = \mathcal{L}_n[1..b] = \mathcal{L}_{n'}[1..b]$, and by Definition 4 $\mathsf{Reg}(P)$ is a function of P, so both nodes hold the same records and the same feasible set $\{(H_{a,v}, v) : H_{a,v} \leq b\}$. By Assumption 2(iii) its elements are pairwise distinct, so the lexicographic maximum in (5) is unique when the set is non-empty, and both nodes return $\perp$ when it is empty; hence $v^*_n(a,b) = v^*_{n'}(a,b)$. No adversarial capability enters this computation: scheduling, preparation timing, crashes and artifact tampering act on node-local state, whereas line 5 of Algorithm 2 evaluates (5) on the registry before any node-local state is consulted. The experiment therefore never outputs 1, whatever the running time of $\mathcal{A}$. □

Theorem 1 is information-theoretic. The next theorem shows that binding the executed bytecode to the registry costs exactly one collision-resistance assumption.

Theorem 2 (Module binding). *Under Assumption 2, for every PPT adversary $\mathcal{A}$ there exists a PPT algorithm $\mathcal{B}$, running in the time of $\mathcal{A}$ plus the cost of simulating the honest nodes, such that*

$$\mathsf{Adv}^{\mathrm{sub}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa) \le \mathsf{Adv}^{\mathrm{cr}}_{\mathrm{Keccak256}}(\mathcal{B}). \tag{8}$$

In particular, $\mathsf{Adv}^{\mathrm{sub}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa)$ is negligible under Assumption 3.

Proof. On input 1^κ, $\mathcal{B}$ runs $\mathsf{Exp}^{\mathrm{sub}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa)$ internally: it simulates the ledger and every honest node, executing Algorithms 1 and 2 on their behalf, and answers the scheduling and artifact-tampering requests of $\mathcal{A}$ exactly as the real experiment would. The simulation is perfect because the model contains no secret state. Whenever a simulated honest node is about to mark (a, v) prepared with $\widehat{C}$ (Algorithm 1, line 12) or to execute $\widehat{C}$ for (a, v) (Algorithm 2, line 14), $\mathcal{B}$ reads $C_{a,v}$ from the simulated registry; if $\widehat{C} \neq C_{a,v}$ it outputs $(\widehat{C}, C_{a,v})$ and halts, and otherwise it eventually outputs $\perp$.

Let E be the event that $\mathsf{Exp}^{\mathrm{sub}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa)$ outputs 1; by perfect simulation, $\Pr[E] = \mathsf{Adv}^{\mathrm{sub}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa)$ in the run of $\mathcal{B}$. On E, an honest node accepted $\widehat{C}$ for (a, v), which happens only after verifying $\mathrm{Keccak256}(\widehat{C}) = h_{a,v}$ against the canonical record (Algorithm 1, line 8; the prepared set is keyed by $h_{a,v}$, so execution reloads the artifact under the same check). By Assumption 2(i), $h_{a,v} = \mathrm{Keccak256}(C_{a,v})$, so $(\widehat{C}, C_{a,v})$ is a collision and $\Pr[E] \le \mathsf{Adv}^{\mathrm{cr}}_{\mathrm{Keccak256}}(\mathcal{B})$, which is (8). The reduction is tight: it loses no advantage and does not guess the target record. □

The control hash binds only the bytecode. The entry and output descriptors, the gas component, and the Activation Block are the remaining fields of the same admitted proposal and are read from the canonical registry. These values are common to honest nodes under the stated ledger assumptions.

Theorem 3 (Upgrade soundness). *Under Assumptions 1–3, EvoCrypt is upgrade sound: for every PPT adversary $\mathcal{A}$ there exists a PPT $\mathcal{B}$ as in Theorem 2 such that*

$$\mathsf{Adv}^{\mathrm{bind}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa) \le \mathsf{Adv}^{\mathrm{cr}}_{\mathrm{Keccak256}}(\mathcal{B}). \tag{9}$$

Proof. Let W be the event that $\mathsf{Exp}^{\mathrm{bind}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa)$ outputs 1 at honest node n for an invocation of a at height b executed with $\widehat{C}$; let $v = v^*(a, b)$ be the canonical selection, v_n the version resolved by n in line 5 of Algorithm 2, and $\hat{v}$ the version under which $\widehat{C}$ was prepared. Then $W \subseteq E_1 \cup E_2 \cup E_3$ with

$$E_1 : v_n \neq v, \qquad E_2 : v_n = v \wedge \hat{v} \neq v_n, \qquad E_3 : \hat{v} = v_n = v \wedge \widehat{C} \neq C_{a,v},$$

since if none occurs then $\widehat{C} = C_{a,v^*(a,b)}$. $\Pr[E_1] = 0$: node n evaluates (5) on $\mathsf{Reg}(\mathcal{L}_n[1..b])$, which by Assumption 1 is the canonical prefix, so the argument of Theorem 1 gives $v_n = v$; if $v = \perp$ the node returns a missing-version error (line 7) and executes nothing. $\Pr[E_2] = 0$: line 9 admits execution only for the resolved pair (a, v_n) and, under the mandatory-preparation policy, continues preparing (a, v_n) rather than falling back to another prepared version, so the only

artifact reaching line 14 was prepared for (a, v_n). E_3 is a module substitution for (a, v) with $\mu_{a,v} \in \mathsf{Reg}(\mathcal{L}_n)$, the latter by Lemma 1(ii) since $H_{a,v} \le b$; hence $\Pr[E_3] \le \mathsf{Adv}^{\mathrm{sub}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa) \le \mathsf{Adv}^{\mathrm{cr}}_{\mathrm{Keccak256}}(\mathcal{B})$ by Theorem 2. A union bound yields (9). □

Remark 1 (Safety versus liveness). Theorems 1–3 are safety statements: an honest node never selects or runs a version other than the canonical one. They do not assert that every node can answer at height $H_{a,v}$; a node still preparing, or in the retry loop of Algorithm 1, defers rather than degrades. Under Assumption 2(iv) and the deterministic validation of Assumption 4, an admitted artifact validates identically at every honest node, so preparation cannot succeed at one node and fail permanently at another; preparation time is measured in Section 5.2 rather than proven here.

4.3 Invocation Security

Section 4.2 fixes *which* artifact an honest node executes. This subsection shows that, once Assumption 4 is added, agreement on the artifact lifts to agreement on the invocation outcome and on the resulting EVM state transition. Assumption 4 is the only new ingredient; it is an engineering assumption on the configured WASM Runtime rather than a cryptographic one, and the statements below make its role explicit. An *outcome* of Algorithm 2 is the pair (o, γ), where o is either the ABI-encoded result y or one of the protocol errors returned by the algorithm, and γ is the gas charged, with $\gamma = 0$ when the algorithm returns before line 14.

Definition 9 (Invocation divergence). *In* $\mathsf{Exp}^{\mathrm{inv}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa)$*, the adversary outputs* (d, g, b, i, n, n')*, where* $n, n' \in \mathcal{N}$ *and* $b \le \min(|\mathcal{L}_n|, |\mathcal{L}_{n'}|)$*. Both nodes run Algorithm 2 with the same request, gas budget, height, and call index. For an actual transaction, preceding charged calls determine* i*. If either node has not produced an outcome, the experiment outputs* 0*; otherwise it outputs* 1 *iff* $(o_n, \gamma_n) \neq (o_{n'}, \gamma_{n'})$*.* $\mathsf{Adv}^{\mathrm{inv}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa) = \Pr[\mathsf{Exp}^{\mathrm{inv}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa) = 1]$.

Returning 0 when a node has not answered keeps the definition a safety property, in line with Remark 1: a node still preparing at line 9 defers and is not counted as disagreeing.

Lemma 2 (Pre-execution agreement). *Under Assumptions 1 and 2, two honest nodes running Algorithm 2 on the same* (d, g, b, i) *take the same branch at every line before line 14, resolve the same version* $v = v^*(a, b)$*, and compute the same* $G_{\mathrm{req}} = G(a, v, x, i, b)$*. In particular, if either node returns an ABI, missing-version or out-of-gas error, both return the same error with* $\gamma = 0$*.*

Proof. Parse is a fixed function of d, so both nodes obtain the same (a, x) or the same ABI error. Theorem 1 gives $v^*_n(a, b) = v^*_{n'}(a, b)$, so the missing-version test agrees. If a version is resolved, both nodes read $\mu_{a,v}$ from $\mathsf{Reg}(\mathcal{L}_n[1..b]) = \mathsf{Reg}(\mathcal{L}_{n'}[1..b])$ (Assumption 1 with Definition 4), hence the same $g^{\mathrm{reg}}_{a,v}$ and ABI

descriptors. They also use the pricing parameters in the gas component of $\mu_{a,v}$, together with the call index i for the common transaction prefix. Thus $|x|$, i, and b determine the same branch and charge under Definition 3 and Eq. (6); comparison with the common budget g yields the same out-of-gas decision. None of these steps reads node-local state other than the prepared set, which only decides whether line 9 must prepare first, not which branch is taken. □

Theorem 4 (Invocation consistency). *Under Assumptions 1–4, for every PPT adversary $\mathcal{A}$ there exists a PPT $\mathcal{B}$ as in Theorem 2 such that*

$$\mathsf{Adv}^{\mathrm{inv}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa) \le \mathsf{Adv}^{\mathrm{cr}}_{\mathrm{Keccak256}}(\mathcal{B}). \tag{10}$$

Moreover, whenever both nodes answer, they charge the same gas unconditionally: $\gamma_n = \gamma_{n'} = G(a, v^*(a,b), x, i, b)$ if line 14 is reached and $\gamma_n = \gamma_{n'} = 0$ otherwise.

Proof. Let W be the event that $\mathsf{Exp}^{\mathrm{inv}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa)$ outputs 1, so both nodes answered and $(o_n, \gamma_n) \neq (o_{n'}, \gamma_{n'})$. Let $v = v^*(a,b)$, and let $\widehat{C}_n, \widehat{C}_{n'}$ be the byte sequences the nodes execute at line 14 when they reach it. Then $W \subseteq F_1 \cup F_2 \cup F_3$ with

$$\begin{aligned} F_1 &: \text{the nodes take different branches before line 14,} \\ F_2 &: \text{both reach line 14 and } \widehat{C}_n \neq C_{a,v} \ \vee \ \widehat{C}_{n'} \neq C_{a,v}, \\ F_3 &: \widehat{C}_n = \widehat{C}_{n'} = C_{a,v} \ \wedge \ o_n \neq o_{n'}, \end{aligned}$$

since if none occurs, both nodes either return the same pre-execution error with $\gamma = 0$, or reach line 14 with the same G_{req}, execute the same bytecode and return the same o. $\Pr[F_1] = 0$ by Lemma 2. F_2 states that some honest node executes an invocation of a at height b with bytecode other than $C_{a,v^*(a,b)}$, which is exactly the winning event of $\mathsf{Exp}^{\mathrm{bind}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa)$; hence $\Pr[F_2] \le \mathsf{Adv}^{\mathrm{bind}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa) \le \mathsf{Adv}^{\mathrm{cr}}_{\mathrm{Keccak256}}(\mathcal{B})$ by Theorem 3. The bound covers both nodes at once because $\mathsf{Exp}^{\mathrm{bind}}$ already quantifies over all honest nodes. $\Pr[F_3] = 0$: on F_3 both nodes evaluate $\mathsf{Exec}(C_{a,v}, x)$ on the same arguments, and by Assumption 4 its output, including any runtime error, is a function of $(C_{a,v}, x)$ and the fixed host interface; ABI encoding of that output under the common $\tau^{\mathrm{out}}_{a,v}$ is deterministic, so $o_n = o_{n'}$. A union bound gives (10). The gas statement is Lemma 2: γ equals G_{req} when line 14 is reached and 0 otherwise, and both quantities agree without any computational assumption. □

The bound in (10) coincides with that of Theorem 3: adding Assumption 4 introduces no further probabilistic loss. The next theorem establishes that an adversary cannot evade the charge prescribed by Definition 3.

Theorem 5 (Gas-charge soundness). *Under Assumptions 1 and 2, every adversary $\mathcal{A}$, including a computationally unbounded one, has $\mathsf{Adv}^{\mathrm{gas}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa) = 0$.*

Proof (Proof sketch). Fix an invocation identified by $\mathcal{A}$ for which G^* is defined. By Assumption 1, node n uses the canonical registry and the gas component of

the proposal for a. Assumption 2(iii) fixes the admitted metadata, so Theorem 1 gives the canonical version $v^*(a,b)$ and its registered charge. The encoded input x and the preceding charged calls determine $|x|$ and i by Definition 3. Hence Definition 3 selects the canonical pricing branch: either the immutable registered charge or Eq. (6) with the parameters in that gas component. In both cases, $G_{\text{req}} = G^*$. Algorithm 2 returns an out-of-gas error when $g < G_{\text{req}}$ and charges G_{req} before execution otherwise. Reaching line 14 therefore implies $g \geq G^*$ and $\gamma = G^*$, excluding both winning events in Definition 8. Thus $\mathsf{Exp}^{\text{gas}}_{\mathcal{A}}(\kappa)$ never outputs 1. □

Theorem 5 establishes adherence to the defined gas schedule; the resource-underpricing risk is addressed separately in Section 4.4.

4.4 Residual Risks and Governed Recovery

Two risks remain inside the model of Section 4.1 after Theorems 1–4: an admitted implementation may later prove unsuitable or vulnerable, and either a registered charge or the gas component of an admitted proposal may underprice or overprice the resources a call consumes. Committee review of the registered charge is trusted but not infallible, and the gas component of each proposal requires its own calibration. EvoCrypt cannot prevent a poor initial choice; a governed version update can replace the implementation, while repricing through version metadata applies only when the gas component of the proposal does not override the registered charge.

Corollary 1 (Governed supersession). *Under Assumptions 1 and 2, let $\mu_{a,v}$ and $\mu_{a,v'}$ be admitted with $H_{a,v'} > H_{a,v}$. Then for every honest node n and every height $H_{a,v'} \leq b \leq |\mathcal{L}_n|$, $v^*_n(a,b) \neq v$. If, moreover, no admitted version of a other than v' has an activation height in $[H_{a,v'}, b]$, then $v^*_n(a,b) = v'$.*

Corollary 1 covers three corrective actions. *Replacement* admits $\mu_{a,v'}$ with new bytecode; from $H_{a,v'}$ on, Theorem 3 guarantees that every honest node runs $C_{a,v'}$ and never $C_{a,v}$. *Repricing* admits $\mu_{a,v'}$ with a revised $g^{\text{reg}}_{a,v'}$ and possibly unchanged bytecode, which Assumption 2(iii) permits because uniqueness is over (a,v) rather than over $h_{a,v}$. This changes the charge only when the registered charge in Definition 3 applies: the gas component of the admitted proposal takes precedence over a revision that changes only $g^{\text{reg}}_{a,v}$. *Deprecation* admits a version whose module returns a protocol error on every input, so that by Theorem 4 all invocations of a fail deterministically after $H_{a,v'}$ without any contract redeployment. In each case, the version change becomes effective $H_{a,v'} - u_{a,v'}$ blocks after admission, and a node is ready at that height whenever its preparation completes within this window (Remark 1); Section 5.3 tests version agreement around activation, not preparation-time sufficiency.

5 Evaluation

The evaluation asks whether replaceable cryptography can offer useful execution performance without losing consistent version selection, and what costs

accompany that flexibility. Section 5.1 establishes the experimental scope. Section 5.2 examines the performance and gas-accounting trade-offs of PBKDF2, while Section 5.3 tests network-wide upgrade consistency and the execution of more complex verifiers. These questions use different experimental settings and therefore support distinct conclusions.

5.1 Experimental Setup

Our prototype extends Geth with a WASM-backed cryptographic coprocessor. For upgrade validation, we deployed 20 Geth nodes as containers on a private Clique network with five-second blocks. The containers each have a limit of half a CPU and 768 MB of memory; they are not 20 separate physical servers. TODO: confirm the host hardware and operating system for this run.

The evaluation uses different settings for its three questions. Upgrade consistency is observed across the 20-node network; the PBKDF2 comparison concerns a single node, and the complex-verifier results are independent microbenchmarks. PBKDF2 derives a 32-byte key using HMAC-SHA-256. The time comparison varies its internal iteration count from 1 to 100, whereas the gas comparison fixes two iterations and varies the number n of calls per transaction. For PBKDF2, Eq. (6) uses the gas parameters of that algorithm's proposal, $B_a(|x|) = g_0 = 3000$ for the tested inputs, $\alpha_a = 1/2$, and $N_{0,a} = 2$; the rule replaces the registered charge rather than supplementing it.

5.2 Performance Evaluation

Moving PBKDF2 out of Solidity is advantageous in this comparison primarily as the work per call grows. EvoCrypt is marginally slower at one internal iteration but substantially faster at 100 iterations, where the recorded times are 2.967 ms and 8.152 ms, respectively. Figure 3 therefore supports a workload-dependent benefit rather than a claim of uniformly faster calls. The native precompile remains the fastest recorded path, illustrating the cost of replaceability relative to a built-in implementation. Its nearly flat time series, however, does not track the increasing PBKDF2 work; TODO: verify the native series and the plotted timing boundary before inferring how this overhead scales.

The gas advantage under the current tariff is a pricing outcome, not evidence of reduced computation. EvoCrypt's archived single-call gas figure remains at 48,136 even as PBKDF2 iterations increase from 1 to 100, whereas the Solidity charge grows with that work. This reported amount should not be equated with the coprocessor charge G until its measurement boundary is verified; the algorithm's pricing rule itself does not price the internal iteration count. The present schedule thus needs workload-sensitive calibration before a lower bill can be interpreted as faithful resource accounting.

Transaction-level repetition exposes a second limit to claims of cheaper invocation. In the receipt-validated run, EvoCrypt is charged less than Solidity for one call but more for 16 calls, reaching 2.70 million versus 1.19 million gas.

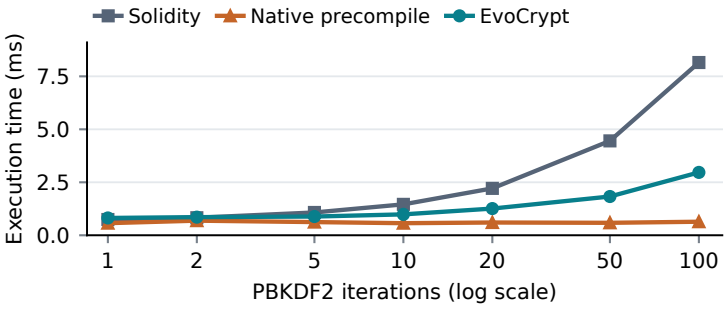


Fig. 3. PBKDF2 time versus internal iterations for Solidity, native precompile, and EvoCrypt. The timing boundary of the archived series requires verification.

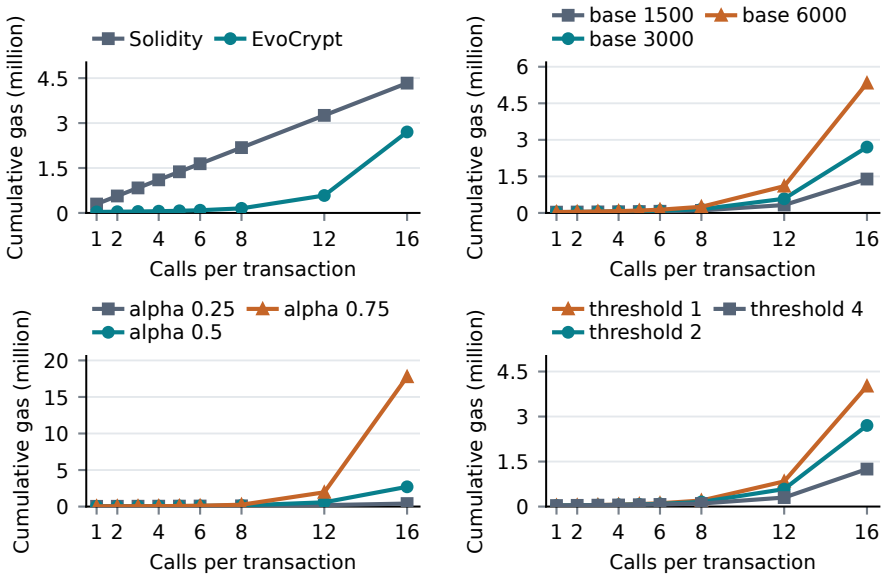


Fig. 4. Cumulative PBKDF2 gas. Top left: Solidity and EvoCrypt; top right: sensitivity to g_0; bottom left: sensitivity to α; bottom right: sensitivity to N_0. The archived curves require reconciliation with the receipt results.

Figure 4 illustrates how the configured tariff varies with call count and its parameters; its archived workbook curves do not match all receipt measurements. Accordingly, neither the small-n saving nor the plotted parameter sensitivities

establish a general gas advantage. TODO: reconcile the two data sources before making quantitative claims from the plotted curves.

5.3 Functional Validation

Asynchronous preparation raises a consistency question: could nodes execute different versions for the same transaction near activation? In the 20-node run with activation at block 25, all 35 fully observed transactions across blocks 22–28 selected v1 before activation and v2 thereafter. For each transaction, the recorded outputs, gas charges, and local state roots agreed across all nodes. The observation concerns agreement at the execution height; it does not require nodes to finish preparing the module at the same wall-clock instant.

A separate late-join scenario tests whether different synchronization histories disrupt the same height-based rule. Figure 5 shows three groups joining and progressing at different times around the scheduled activation at block 20. Their progress and preparation times differ, but the accompanying execution records show the expected version and output on every fully observed transaction around activation. The timeline alone cannot establish execution agreement; the per-node version and output records supply that evidence. Together, the two runs support consistency in the tested settings, without establishing behavior under arbitrary network failures or untested historical replay.

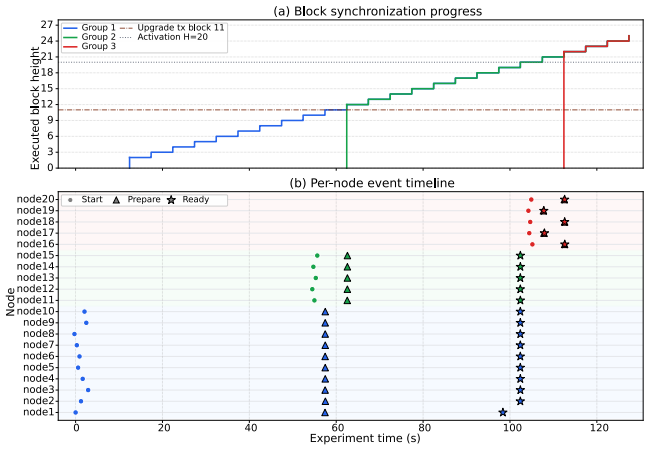


Fig. 5. Late-join consistency scenario with activation at block 20. Top: block progress for three node groups; bottom: their start, preparation, and readiness events. The timeline shows differing local progress; version and output agreement are checked in the per-node execution records.

Algorithm extensibility comes with a measurable but workload-dependent execution cost. EvoCrypt executes all six selected post-quantum signature and

Groth16 proof verifiers in Table 1, extending the interface beyond the PBKDF2 workload. Their WASM-to-native verification-time ratios differ markedly, from about twofold for the signature workloads to more than fivefold for both Groth16 curves. This variation precludes attributing a single fixed overhead to the coprocessor; profiling would be needed to explain the gap. The comparison concerns standalone verification, not proof generation or transaction confirmation.

Table 1. Average and WASM execution; ratios are WASM/native.

Algorithm	Precompile (ms)	WASM (ms)	Ratio
Sha256	0.39	0.51	1.3
Dh2048Secret	0.41	0.6	1.46
PedersenCommit	0.47	1.26	2.68
SchnorrVerify	1.26	3.67	2.91
Aigis-Sig2	0.106	0.226	2.13
Dilithium3	0.141	0.282	2.00
ML-DSA-65	0.141	0.286	2.03
SLH-DSA-SHAKE-192f	3.964	7.585	1.91
Groth16-BLS12-381	3.518	18.809	5.34
Groth16-BN254	2.182	11.676	5.35

6 Conclusion

EvoCrypt addresses the problem of evolving contract-facing cryptographic capabilities without embedding complex algorithms in EVM bytecode or modifying the client for every update. Its design separates the stable contract-facing interface from replaceable client-side WASM implementations, while deterministic version selection and algorithm-level accounting preserve consistent invocation rules.

Future work will focus on two directions. First, we will develop a more accurate gas-pricing model that reflects the computational and memory costs of cryptographic operations while retaining deterministic charges across nodes. Second, we will investigate execution and scheduling strategies to reduce the transaction-validation latency introduced by complex algorithms in the coprocessor. The aim is to limit delays to block production while preserving deterministic execution and agreement across nodes.

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